

agreement and the North Vietnamese, assuming Thieu would resign before any election, relented on their demand that he give up power immediately. They then presented an outline framework for an agreement.



At the negotiating table

US and North Vietnamese negotiators, including Henry Kissinger (fourth from right) and Le Duc Tho (fourth from left), meet in Paris on January 13, 1973, to continue discussions on terms for a ceasefire agreement.

First draft emerges

By August 10, there was a draft ceasefire agreement. Kissinger and Le Duc Tho met on August 14 to hammer out details. Kissinger visited Saigon on August 17. Thieu rejected the idea of a “commission” that could become a coalition government, and any ceasefire that did not force the North Vietnamese to withdraw from the South. Kissinger nevertheless asked Thieu to help to extend the negotiations until Nixon, with a renewed presidential mandate in November, could unleash a new show of force against the North.

Thieu reiterated his objections and made a bid for a grand negotiation at an all-Southeast Asia conference where he might hope to minimize the influence of the North by making them just one player. Meanwhile, Kissinger’s deputy, Alexander Haig, arrived in Saigon at the end of September. Unbeknown to the South Vietnamese, Haig carried a new plan for bombing North Vietnam, which he discussed with American air commanders.

Thieu pushes back

After a final round of Paris talks, Kissinger returned to Saigon with a final draft ceasefire agreement. He had intended to go on to Hanoi, where the paper would be initialed ahead of a formal signing. Thieu, however, rebelled, making the very same objections that he had tabled earlier. Instead of traveling to Hanoi, Henry Kissinger returned to Washington. At